bar, nursing a stubbie. When he does speak, his views are intelligent, well thought out and to the point. He was great for me because he wanted me to lead on my own initiative, rather than slavishly following a preordained plan.

That Ashes series would be my redemption. No one really gave us too much of a chance, but I sensed something stirring during a training camp in Spain. We didn't take cricket bats. We concentrated on slip catching for hours and spoke honestly to one another about our expectations. Scar tissue began to heal.

There was no point in hiding from the reality, that we had been humiliated the previous year. Mitchell Johnson was still being spoken of as a major threat. Yet Trevor, in his understated way, cut through recently formed reputations. He broke down the Australians both as players and as people, highlighting technical flaws and well-disguised fears.

Having destroyed the mystique, he then concentrated on our own outlook. We would follow the McCullum principle, and be open to both the public and, most pertinently, the opposition. We had nothing to hide and would have a lot to be proud of. Three days before the first Test we invited the Aussies into our dressing room after the game, win or lose.

Darren Lehmann, their coach, refused. We thought it strange, because there were no ulterior motives involved. Their reaction suggested they were just like us, human beings with inconsistencies and insecurities. We were at ease. We would play without fear and avoid the blame game if things went wrong. It was liberating, and, for the Aussies, disconcerting. I was encouraged to be unorthodox in my captaincy, and to embrace calculated risk.

Perhaps I overdid my bit for team morale by being hit in the balls, attempting to collect a sharply bouncing ricochet. Boy, did it hurt. Joe Root was in hysterics as the doctor came on to count them, for the first time since I was about thirteen. I forgave him, through the thinnest of smiles, because he had changed the complexion of a match played on a low, slow wicket.

The beauty of sport, and also its terror, is captured by two words, 'if only'. Things could have played out so differently had Rooty not been dropped, second ball, by Brad Haddin. We would have been 43–4 on the first morning and facing familiar demons. He scored 194 runs over the match, took two wickets with his occasional off-spin, and claimed the winning catch off Moeen Ali.